Travelling Right

Actor **Pankaj Tripathi** on travel, the great lockdown and cinematic escapes



SARIKA GANGWAL

Did the pandemic change your travel philosophy?

I might have travelled less during the pandemic, but I don't think my travel philosophy changed. I still want to see more, wander more, but I also want to ensure that I leave a smaller carbon footprint. The pandemic, yes, has made me more conscious of what I waste. That ethic applies to travel and my life.

You came from Bihar to Bombay because you wanted to be an actor, but is it also true that you made this journey because you simply wanted to travel?

Absolutely, I became an actor because I knew it would let me travel for free. As a theatre actor, I wanted to go to Jaipur, Udaipur and Kashmir, but now I have work that allows me to see the world.

Since your job takes you to so many places, what does going on holiday feel like?

If I see a place I like while shooting, I instantly put it on the family holiday bucket list. When I go back to that place with my wife and daughter a few months later, I mostly sit quietly and take in the beauty.

If you had to pick three winter destinations for our readers this year, which would they be?

North Bengal: I think I am going to become the unannounced brand ambassador of North Bengal very soon. [Laughs] I did a film there and I stayed in places like Lataguri, Buxa Forest and Gorumara. The beauty of all these places was altogether staggering. There are tea estates there in the middle of forests and from there, you can see the Kanchenjunga. I can't wait to go back there.

Rann of Kutch: I remember being in the Rann of Kutch on a full-moon night in winter with my family. The whole experience was surreal. I am the kind of person who relies on his eyes more than his camera when he travels, so trust me when I say this—the Rann of Kutch is something else in winter.

Meghalaya: The mountains are always a treat. I am very fond of Leh-Ladakh, but for this one time, I will recommend Meghalaya. I went there two-three years ago because I really wanted to see the Dawki river and I wanted to stay in places like Shillong and Maolilong. It was a holiday I cherish.

- with Shreevatsa Nevatia